

In charge: Leggie Wanindu Hasaranga was named captain of Sri Lanka after missing the IPL to get fit in time for the T20 World Cup. AFP

games. In the last two editions, the first round had two groups of four, which included teams that entered the tournament through the qualifying pathway and teams that finished between ninth and 12th in the previous T20 World Cup. However, this time, 20 teams will be divided into four groups of five in the first round, followed by a Super Eights phase.

The Sri Lankan unit is built around its bowling attack, which is tailor-made for the slower surfaces that are expected in the second round of the World Cup in the Caribbean. Tweakers Hasaranga and Maheesh Theekshana have had economy rates of 7.42 and 6.71, respectively, in T20Is since 2022. The pair, along with quicks Matheesha Pathirana and Dilshan Madushanka, will be vital in containing the opposition's scoring rate.

Sri Lanka would hope the rigours of captaincy in high-stake contests do not weigh down on Hasaranga's performances.

If the bowlers play their part, the experience of Angelo Mathews, Kusal Mendis, and Dasun Shanaka with the bat can take Sri Lanka over the line.

The time is now for Bangladesh

Ending its series of near misses in the T20 World Cup will top Bangladesh's priority list.

It could have been in contention for a semifinal spot in 2022 if not for its agonising five-run reverse to India via the Duckworth-Lewis Stern Method. In 2016, Bangladesh missed the semifinal berth due to a one-run loss against the same opponent.

The Bangla Tigers have gone with experienced names like Soumya Sarkar, Litton Das, Mustafizur Rahman, and Taskin Ahmed in both batting and bowling departments. If Najmul Hossain Shanto, still relatively new as a full-time captain, can efficiently marshall his troops, Bangladesh will stay in the hunt for



the next round. A run to the Super 8, and eventually the semifinals, will also serve as the perfect farewell for its veteran duo of Shakib Al Hasan and Mahmudullah, both likely to be playing their final World Cup.

Netherlands and Nepal will decide the qualifiers

The Netherlands and Nepal might not be in the race to advance to the next round, but their fixtures will decide the fate of the other three teams. No team would know it better than South Africa and Bangladesh.

The Netherlands showed it can punch above its weight in the 50-over World Cup when it beat South Africa and Bangladesh in the round-robin stage. Most names from that squad—Scott Edwards, Max O'Dowd, Logan van Beek and Bas de Leede—were retained for the T20 World Cup.

Nepal qualified for only its second T20 World Cup after finishing as runner-up in the Asian qualifiers behind Oman. Even though it is mostly against Associate nations, the Rohit Paudel-led side has shown a flair for the extraordinary.

Dipendra Singh Airee struck six

sixes in an over against Qatar in April, becoming only the third batter after Yuvraj Singh and Kieron Pollard to manage the feat in T20Is. During the 2023 Asian Games, Airee struck a nine-ball half-century against Mongolia to better Yuvraj's record for the fastest fifty.

In the same match, Nepal became the first team to score 300 runs or more in a T20I.

The bigger teams in the World Cup will be a tough test for Nepal, but its record over the last year has piqued viewer interest.

Two teams that will qualify

South Africa and Sri Lanka: The sheer star power makes South Africa a favourite for the top spot. Sri Lanka is likely to edge past Bangladesh for second place, given its better head-to-head record in the recent encounters.

Dark Horse

Of the three major teams, Bangladesh probably has the ideal blend of youth and experience. If it can have its best players on top of their game, Bangladesh might change its all-too-familiar tale of stumbling at crucial junctures.